

Insomnia and Excessive Daytime Sleepiness (EDS)

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The most commonly reported [sleep-related problems](#) are insomnia and excessive daytime sleepiness.

- **Insomnia** is difficulty falling asleep or staying asleep, waking up early, or a disturbance in sleep quality that makes sleep seem inadequate or unrefreshing.
- **Excessive daytime sleepiness** refers to being unusually sleepy or falling asleep during the day.

(See also [Overview of Sleep](#).)

Insomnia can be a disorder or can be a symptom of other disorders. Excessive daytime sleepiness is not a disorder but a symptom of various sleep-related disorders.

Difficulty falling and staying asleep and waking up earlier than desired are common among young and old. Many adults have long-standing (chronic) insomnia, and many more sometimes have insomnia.

Did You Know...

- Many people have insomnia at one time or another.
- Prescription sleep aids and over-the-counter sleep aids that contain [diphenhydramine](#) (an antihistamine) are not good choices for treating insomnia.
- The best treatment for insomnia is cognitive-behavioral therapy, which includes changes in behavior to improve sleep.

When [sleep](#) is disturbed, people sometimes cannot function normally during the day. People with insomnia or excessive daytime sleepiness are sleepy, tired, and irritable

during the day and have trouble concentrating and functioning. People with excessive daytime sleepiness may fall asleep when working or driving.

There are different types of insomnia:

- **Difficulty falling asleep (sleep-onset insomnia):** Commonly, people have difficulty falling asleep when they cannot let their mind relax and they continue to think and worry. Sometimes the body is not ready for sleep at what is considered a usual time for sleep. That is, the body's internal clock is out of sync with the earth's cycle of light and dark—as can occur with many types of [circadian rhythm sleep disorders](#), such as delayed sleep phase disorder, shift work disorder, and jet lag.
- **Difficulty staying asleep and waking up earlier than desired (sleep maintenance insomnia):** People with this type of insomnia fall asleep normally but wake up several hours later and cannot fall asleep again easily. Sometimes they drift in and out of a restless, unsatisfactory sleep. Sleep maintenance insomnia is more common among older adults, who are more likely to have difficulty staying asleep than are younger adults. It may occur in people who use certain substances (such as caffeine, alcohol, or tobacco) or who take certain medications and in people who have certain sleep disorders (such as [sleep apnea](#) or [periodic limb movement disorder](#)). This type of insomnia may be a sign of depression in people of any age.

Causes of Insomnia and EDS

Insomnia and excessive daytime sleepiness may be caused by conditions inside or outside the body. Some conditions cause insomnia and excessive daytime sleepiness, and some cause one or the other. Some people have chronic insomnia that has little or no apparent relationship to any particular cause. Genetic factors may be involved.

Common causes

Insomnia is most often caused by

- Poor sleep habits, such as drinking a caffeinated beverage in the late afternoon or evening, exercising late at night, or having an irregular sleep-wake schedule
- Mental health disorders, particularly depression, anxiety, and substance use disorders

- Other disorders such as heart and lung disorders, disorders that affect muscles or bones, or chronic pain
- Stress, such as that due to hospitalization, loss of a job, or a death in the family (called adjustment insomnia)
- Excessive worrying about sleeplessness and another day of fatigue (called psychophysiologic insomnia)

Sleeping late or napping to make up for lost sleep may make sleeping during the next night even harder.

Excessive daytime sleepiness is most often caused by

- Insufficient sleep despite having ample opportunity to sleep (called insufficient sleep syndrome)
- [Obstructive sleep apnea](#) (a serious disorder in which breathing frequently stops during sleep)
- Various disorders, particularly mental health disorders, brain or nerve (neurologic) disorders (such as [encephalitis](#), [meningitis](#), a [brain tumor](#), or [narcolepsy](#)), and disorders that affect muscles or bones
- Disorders that disrupt people's internal sleep-wake schedule ([circadian rhythm disorders](#)), such as jet lag and shift work disorder

Most major mental health disorders are accompanied by insomnia and excessive daytime sleepiness. About 80% of people with major depression have excessive daytime sleepiness and insomnia, and many people with chronic insomnia have a mental health disorder, usually [depression](#) or an [anxiety disorder](#).

Any disorder that causes pain or discomfort, particularly if worsened by movement, can cause brief awakenings and interfere with sleep.

Less common causes

Medications, when used for a long time or when stopped (withdrawal), can cause insomnia and excessive daytime sleepiness.



Some Drugs That Interfere With Sleep

Type	Examples
When the drug is used	
Antiseizure medications	<u>Phenytoin</u>
Chemotherapy agents	All
Drugs that stimulate the brain	Amphetamines
	<u>Caffeine</u>
Beta blockers	<u>Propranolol</u>
Steroids	Anabolic steroids
	Corticosteroids
Thyroid hormone preparations	—
When the drug is stopped	
Recreational and illicit drugs	Cocaine
	Heroin
	Marijuana
	Phencyclidine
Drugs that slow the brain	Barbiturates
	Opioids
	Sedatives
When the drug is used or stopped	
Alcohol	—



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Antidepressants

Selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors (SSRIs), such as fluoxetine

Serotonin-norepinephrine reuptake inhibitors, such as duloxetine

Monoamine oxidase inhibitors (MAOIs), such as selegiline